

SEO + content engines

Week 6, Lecture 2, B2C to \$10k MRR

Growth Manual for Technical Founders · Autumn 2026

What we'll cover

- Programmatic SEO: what it is and why it fits solo founders
- Nomad List as the canonical case study
- Topic clusters and the lighthouse article pattern
- Backlinks: what is realistic for an indie product
- Page 1 in 12 weeks: when possible, when not
- Google Search Console as an acquisition funnel

Programmatic SEO

What programmatic SEO is

Traditional SEO: write one article targeting one keyword. Publish. Wait.

Programmatic SEO: build a template + a database. Every row in the database becomes a page. Every page targets a different long-tail keyword.

- Template: `/tool/[use-case]` or `/compare/[product-a]-vs-[product-b]`
- Database: your product's own data, public data, or user-generated content
- Output: hundreds or thousands of unique, indexable pages

The key insight: the work is in building the database and the template, not in writing each page individually.

Why it fits solo founders

1. **One-time engineering investment:** build the template once; the pages scale automatically as the database grows.
2. **Long-tail coverage:** 8 billion Google searches per day; most of the volume is in queries that individual articles will never target.
3. **Compounding without daily effort:** pages rank passively while you focus on product.
4. **Defensible:** competitors cannot easily copy a database-driven URL structure without building their own data.

Source: Pieter Levels, *MAKE* (2019); IH Podcast #043 (2018)

Nomad List: the full breakdown

The database:

- ~200+ cities, each with 20+ data points (cost of living, internet speed, weather, safety score)
- All crowdsourced initially, then automated via API feeds

The URL structure:

- `/nomad-list/<city>`, one page per city
- `/nomad-list/<city>/cost-of-living`, faceted subpages per topic
- Comparison pages: `/compare/<city-a>-vs-<city-b>`

The conversion path:

1. User searches "best city for digital nomads" or "Bangkok cost of living for remote workers"
2. Lands on the city page (free, no login)
3. Wants to filter cities by budget + internet speed → hits the paywall
4. Converts to membership (\$99-\$149/year at various stages)

Nomad List: the numbers

Levels built Nomad List as part of his 12-startups-in-12-months challenge in 2014.

- Started as a spreadsheet posted on Twitter; hit Product Hunt #1 the same day
- Grew to \$15-25k/month within months of launch
- Reached \$20-40k/month with thousands of paying members (Levels, 2024)

The SEO component was not the initial growth driver. Product Hunt and Hacker News were the kickstart. SEO became the **compounding engine** that sustained growth after the launch spike faded.

Topic clusters

The lighthouse article pattern

A **topic cluster** is a set of pages organized around one central topic:

- **Lighthouse article:** a long, authoritative page targeting a broad, high-intent head keyword. 2,000-4,000 words. Links out to supporting pages.
- **Supporting pages:** shorter, more specific pages each targeting a long-tail variation. Each links back to the lighthouse.

Why it works: search engines interpret internal linking patterns as a signal of topical authority. A cluster signals that your site owns the topic.

Example: lighthouse = "best remote work tools 2026" → supporting pages = "best async video tools", "best time zone tools for distributed teams", "remote team calendar apps"

Building a topic cluster: the process

1. Name the head keyword your lighthouse will target. Use search volume data (Google Keyword Planner, free tier) to confirm it gets at least 500 searches/month.
2. List 8-12 long-tail variations. These become your supporting page titles.
3. Write the lighthouse article first. Make it the best page on the internet for that query.
4. Publish supporting pages over 4-6 weeks. Each one links to the lighthouse.
5. Add internal links from the lighthouse to each supporting page as they go live.

Do not reverse this order. The lighthouse anchors the cluster; it must exist before the supporting pages.

Backlinks

Backlinks: the honest picture

A backlink is a link from another website to yours. Google uses backlinks as a trust signal: more high-quality backlinks generally means higher rankings.

What works for indie products:

- Free tools that others embed or link to (Marc Lou's free-tool strategy)
- Being cited in round-up posts ("best tools for X")
- Guest posts on niche newsletters or blogs
- Product Hunt and Hacker News launches (temporary spike + permanent backlinks)
- Directory listings (Product Hunt, Indie Hackers, G2 where relevant)

What does not work for solo founders:

- Cold email outreach for link exchanges (response rate near zero)
- Paying for links (violates Google's guidelines; risks a manual penalty)

Marc Lou's free-tool backlink strategy

Marc Lou's free-tool marketing approach (2024):

- Build a free mini-app that solves one problem, no signup required
- The tool has a descriptive name that includes the target keyword
- Others share and embed it; each share is a potential backlink
- The conversion path: free tool → "want more?" → paid product

He reported 30% conversion from free tool users to paid product, driven by the natural overlap between the tool's problem and the product's problem.

The backlinks from embeds and shares fed the SEO for the main product at no additional cost.

(Marc Lou, free tool marketing, 2024)

Page 1 in 12 weeks

When it is possible

You can reach page 1 in 12 weeks if all of these are true:

1. You target a **long-tail query** with low competition (e.g., "remote team timezone tool for async standups" not "productivity tool")
2. Your domain is at least a few months old with any existing content
3. You publish a genuinely useful page that answers the query better than current results
4. You get at least 2-3 natural backlinks from relevant sites

Thumbtack's SEO team spent 18-24 months building to meaningful traffic before the channel paid off. (Rachitsky, 2022, growth engines)

For a 12-week course, the realistic goal is: **establish the foundation, get GSC impressions, see early clicks.**

When it is not possible

Do not expect page 1 in 12 weeks if:

- You are targeting head keywords with domain authority scores in the 60-80+ range among top results
- Your domain is brand new (no history, no backlinks)
- Your product category is dominated by well-funded competitors with content teams
- You have published fewer than 5 substantial pages

The right frame: SEO is a 6-24 month channel. Starting it in week 6 means the compound interest arrives by month 9-12, which is after the course. That is still worth doing.

Google Search Console

GSC as an acquisition funnel

Google Search Console tracks three metrics (Google, 2026):

Step	Metric	What it measures
Top	Impressions	Times your link appeared in search results
Middle	Clicks	Times someone clicked to your site
Bottom	CTR	Clicks / impressions

Add one more step: **activation** (your north star metric from week 1). Now you have a full acquisition funnel: impressions → clicks → activation → paid.

Reading GSC: what to watch

Week 6 baseline: record impressions, clicks, average position, indexed pages. Most new sites start at zero.

Signals that content is working:

- Impressions rising week-over-week (pages are being discovered)
- Average position improving (moving from page 4 to page 2)
- CTR above 2-3% (title and meta description are earning the click)

Signals that content needs work:

- High impressions, low CTR: title is not compelling for the query
- Low impressions: page is not indexed or keyword is too narrow
- High CTR, low activation: landing page does not deliver what the search result promised

(Google Search Console documentation, 2026)

The GSC funnel interpreted

```
Impressions: 10,000 / week (pages are indexing, good)
Clicks:      300 / week   (CTR 3%, healthy for informational queries)
Activation:  12 / week   (4% activation from search, benchmark to improve)
Paid:        2 / week   (17% of activated users from search convert to paid)
```

Each drop in the funnel is a different problem:

- Low clicks from impressions: fix the title/meta description
- Low activation from clicks: fix the landing page or onboarding
- Low paid from activation: price or value proposition issue (weeks 3-5 work)

Take-aways

1. Programmatic SEO turns a database into thousands of indexable pages, the engineering investment replaces writing each page individually.
2. Nomad List's conversion path is the canonical model: free city data → paywall for filtering → membership. SEO sustained growth after the Product Hunt kickstart faded.
3. A topic cluster (1 lighthouse article + 8-12 supporting pages) signals topical authority to search engines. Write the lighthouse first.
4. Realistic backlinks for indie founders come from free tools, directory listings, and launch spikes, not from outreach campaigns.
5. Google Search Console is a four-step funnel: impressions → clicks → activation → paid. Each step reveals a different optimization target.

I just shipped it. I didn't ask for permission. I shipped it and saw if people wanted it.

Pieter Levels, Lex Fridman Podcast #440 (2024)

What's next

- **Section this week:** Channel-fit worksheet. If you scored SEO highest, come with your GSC verified.
- **HW3:** Wedge channel sprint. Due week 7. Your lighthouse article or channel-equivalent piece is part of the deliverable.
- **Week 7:** Virality, referral loops, and mobile growth. Your channel commitment carries forward.
- **Reading:** Week 6 reading at </c/b2c-10k-mrr-26au/readings/wk06> covers all today's concepts in depth.

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